



Lilawati and her husband Ramprasad (left)

Leela Bati and Balkrishan (right)

with passbooks of their bank accounts into which Rs 300 is deposited each month. Both women's husbands are "dead" in official records.

Photographs by MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

month. "This racket cannot function without the connivance of officials at the village level to the district level officer," says a bank manager. "It's not the bank's job to verify details of a beneficiary. The district administration officials have to do it. It is obvious that the district officials have bypassed the regular procedure."

"I could never imagine a racket of this nature and magnitude," says Divya Trivedi, manager of the Rajdhani Nagar Sahakari Bank in Lucknow. The bank has nearly 6,000 accounts of the Widow Pension Scheme and the Old Age Pension Scheme. Trivedi's suspicion led him to verify some of the pensions. What he stumbled upon was as astounding as it was appalling. "I was shocked to find that most of the women under the Widow Pension Scheme were actually married and should not have been beneficiaries. I could never imagine that a married woman could pretend

to be a widow to claim just Rs 300 a month," he says. He promptly prepared a detailed report and dispatched it to the district administration for action despite threats from some officials and middlemen. The Lucknow district administration is yet to act on Trivedi's report.

"This is a case of just one bank in Lucknow, which has over 1,000 banks," says R.K. Mittal, Commissioner, Social Welfare Department. "If all the beneficiaries are identified it could be one of the biggest scams relating to Government funds with the involvement of govern-

ment officials, middlemen and the 'widows'," he says. When cornered, the women blame the middlemen for forcing them into declaring themselves widows to claim the pension, of which a cut goes to officials and the touts. Hundreds of bank passbooks and pension-related forms have been recovered from a Lucknow NGO called Hamara Haq, headed by Shah Alam.

The racket has penetrated deep into rural areas. In Azamgarh, the racketeers prepared a list of widows in a village to fleece the government. Neither the widows nor the village exist. In villages such as Duiji,



“Most of the women under the Widow Pension Scheme are married and should not have been beneficiaries. This scam is impossible without the connivance of Government officials.” DIVYA TRIVEDI, bank manager